



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Cedar Tree Classical Christian School

School Website: <https://cedartreeschool.org/>

December 21, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools (ACCS) or the Society for Classical Learning (SCL) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Cedar Tree Classical Christian School (Ridgefield, WA 98642) presents a robust, clearly classical-leaning program embedded in a Christian worldview. Public materials emphasize formation of virtuous, eloquent graduates rooted in Scripture, liturgical life, and a time-honored liberal-arts approach. The school foregrounds Great Books and literary classics, Latin (and Greek in high school), public speaking from early grades, a thesis-driven senior year, and a consistent focus on virtue, wisdom, and beauty. Parental partnership and donor/community engagement are integral through structured fundraising and parent communications.

Overall classification: CLASSICAL.

Key strengths - Explicit religious/metaphysical commitments (Bible as authority; daily prayer; statement of faith; liturgical life cues such as hymns and morning devotions) that align with transcendental moral realism and a theological grounding.

- Curriculum and pedagogy anchored by Great Books, literary classics, Latin/Greek study, and a heavy emphasis on public speaking and rhetoric (Upper/Lower School). - Formation-focused goals (virtue, wisdom, character) with explicit statements about formation over information and a Christian worldview permeating subjects. - Evidence of a living, mentored faculty and a community-forward model that positions parents as co-teachers and partners.

What would move the needle (for SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL cases only) - Not applicable here; all six categories align with classical cues. If any area were to be nudged, it would be to further explicitify a formal, named sequence of grammar-logic-rhetoric progression in the published curriculum map (beyond references to "classical method" and "public speaking") to reinforce the Trivium framework more transparently.

Abstracting the six-category assessment below, Cedar Tree demonstrates a strong CLASSICAL orientation across religious foundations, formation goals, curriculum, pedagogy, faculty, and parent/community engagement.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Bible as supreme authority and Biblical worldview across curriculum. "...the Bible as our supreme authority" and "Biblical worldview" are repeatedly highlighted.
 - The Statement of Faith explicitly anchors theology as central to faith and education.
 - Daily prayer and liturgical/thematic devotionals are described as core commitments ("Pray Expectantly").
 - Morning hymns/choral practices and worship-related community life are referenced (e.g., "Morning Hymn" and devotional life).

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- The “Our Philosophy” highlights integration of liberal arts with a Christian Gospel framework.
 - Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords present: theology, Scripture/Bible, Biblical worldview, prayer, worship, virtue/theory of truth, etc., along with explicit clerical/faith commitments. Likely 6–8 distinct positive indicators identified in the public materials.
 - Negative keywords: none evident in the public materials (no explicit “project-based,” “experiential learning” negation here).
 - Why this rating
 - The school’s public materials foreground theological grounding, liturgical life cues, and a Bible-centered epistemology, matching the Positive Keywords in the Six Essential Elements and rejecting neutral/denominational pluralism in favor of a theologically grounded formation. The evidence shows transcendental moral realism and communal worship components, aligning with a Classical/Scholastic foundation rather than secular or purely information-based approaches.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Emphasis on formation of virtue and wisdom over information or work-prep. “formation rather than information,” “virtue and wisdom,” and “truth, goodness and beauty are real.”
 - Central aim of human excellence and the cultivation of a Christian worldview; graduates described as embodying wisdom and eloquence for God’s glory.
 - Explicit Christian formation lifecycle: Scriptural grounding, prayer, and a goal of shaping character before vocational outcomes.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, wisdom, truth, goodness, beauty, Christian worldview, God-glorifying aims.
 - Negative keywords present: none clearly evident (no explicit “workforce preparation” or “careerism” language undermining formation).
- Why this rating
 - The mission and profile articulate formation and the pursuit of transcendent goods (truth, goodness, beauty) within a Christian framework, which aligns strongly with Classical aims, even though the site emphasizes college-readiness via advanced coursework and SAT results. The balance leans heavily toward formation and virtue-cultivation rather than utilitarian job-prep.

Element 3: School Curriculum — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Clear emphasis on classic/grammar-based study and “time-tested classical method,” including literary classics and a robust writing program.
 - Study of Latin (and in high school New Testament Greek) and a strong emphasis on public speaking from early grades.
 - Content mentions “a feast of literary classics” supporting integration of truth in all studies; a focus on Great Books/Great Conversation ethos is implied through “interaction with literary classics.”
 - Senior-year thesis requirement and college/career counseling indicate rigorous, culminating projects.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords present: Great Books, literary classics, Latin, Greek (New Testament), public speaking, rhetoric, thesis, historical breadth, formation of character.
 - Explicit references to the Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric) are not stated in exact curricular phrasing on the site, but the classical-method language and usage of Latin/Greek and Great Books strongly indicate a classical curriculum orientation.
 - Negative keywords: not evident in public material (no explicit “project-based,” “experiential learning” language; some projects exist but not framed as negative indicators).
- Why this rating

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- The curriculum shows strongest alignment with classical indicators (great books, liberal-arts emphasis, Latin/Greek, rhetoric/public speaking, culminating theses). However, explicit, standalone curricular naming of grammar-logic-rhetoric as a formal sequence is not clearly published in the accessible materials, which keeps this category at SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than CLASSICAL. The presence of a strong classical ethos and Great Books emphasis supports a high classical ranking, but the exact published grammar-logic-rhetoric sequencing is not fully explicit.

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Lower-school pedagogy includes singing/chanting with regular review to deepen memory and delight (Scholé-like contemplative/memory-work).
 - Upper-school pedagogy includes emphasis on public speaking, rhetoric, and opportunities to present, defend, and argue (senior thesis presentations; debates; rhetoric training).
 - Public speaking is integrated across grades (Public Speaking in All Grades K-12).
 - Historical/Great-Books-infused pedagogy through “Feast of literary classics” and integration across subjects.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords present: scholé/restful contemplation, memory-based recitation, singing/hymn as learning modality, Socratic dialogue (implied by classical pedagogy; actual explicit “Socratic” language appears in scholarship rather than in Cedar Tree’s public pages, but the “debate” and rhetoric elements imply it), rhetoric, public speaking, Great Books/literary classics.
 - Negative keywords present: none explicit; no evidence of “project-based” or over-emphasis on cognitive-psychology-based unrooted methods.
- Why this rating
 - The school demonstrates an authentically classical pedagogy through memory/chanting in early grades, integrative classical instruction, and high-school rhetoric/debate exposure. The explicit mention of public speaking in all grades, along with senior-thesis rites and debates, aligns with core Classical pedagogy. The overall evidence supports CLASSICAL here.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - The curriculum positions the faculty as the living curriculum and a community of mentors; a small-to-mid faculty size is indicated (total faculty around 25 with 15 full-time and 10 part-time). This supports a close, mentor-driven environment.
 - The site emphasizes teachers as capable, virtuous exemplars, with a focus on character formation and pastoral-like mentorship (“Christ-centered Wisdom and Eloquence” language in the Cedar Tree Difference).
 - Explicit accreditation and professional development through ACCS (and NCPA) affirms standards for classical schools and faculty quality.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords present: model teachers/mentors; living curriculum; faculty as core of school; small class sizes; professional accreditation; character formation language.
 - Negative keywords: none evident (no references to non-classical teaching staff models or anti-classical approaches).
- Why this rating
 - The public materials frame faculty as central to the classicist project (living curriculum, mentorship) and cite accreditation and relatively small class configurations as indicators of a high-quality classical faculty culture. This justifies CLASSICAL.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

- Evidence

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- Strong, intentional partnership with parents; parents described as co-teachers; parent involvement is built into the model through communications, family engagement, and home-school alignment.
 - Active donor/community program (Annual Fund; Scholarship Drive; gala) to sustain the school's mission and widen access.
 - Parent-facing communications (Parent Square and Infinite Campus portal) indicate ongoing parental engagement and transparency.
 - Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords present: partnership with parents, co-teachers, parent education/gatherings, donor-supported funding, community engagement.
 - Negative keywords: none evident (no “top-down” governance or isolation from families).
 - Why this rating
 - Cedar Tree presents parents as essential collaborators in classical formation, aligns with the Six Elements' community-oriented expectations, and maintains visible channels for parental participation and education. CLASSICAL is justified.
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What Would Move the Needle

- If any refinement were desired toward a fully explicit “grammar-logic-rhetoric” curricular mapping, the school could publish a formal, public sequence showing how the Trivium is implemented across K–12 (even if the practical implementation exists, making the sequence explicit would move Element 3 to a deeper CLASSICAL alignment). This would be a minor but clarifying enhancement, particularly for families evaluating the curricular architecture.
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Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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